



Activity Report

National Project Inception Meeting I AM GIRL VI Project

National (Uganda) | 26th February | Protea Hotel Kampala Kololo

List of Abbreviations / Acronyms

Acronym

Meaning

FOL	Fields of Life.
SDGs	Sustainable Development Goals.
WASH	Water, Sanitation and Hygiene.
SRHR	Sexual and Reproductive Health and Rights.
DEO	District Education Officer.
DCDO	District Community Development Officer.
LC V	Local Council Five.
MGLSD	Ministry of Gender, Labour and Social Development.
DHIS II	District Health Information Software 2.
LMIS	Logistics Management Information System.



Introduction

Fields of Life convened a **High Level National Project Inception Meeting** for the I AM GIRL VI Project on 26th February 2026 at Protea Hotel, Kololo – Kampala.

The meeting brought together representatives from the Attorney General's Office, Busoga Kingdom, Parliament, religious institutions, development partners, children and implementing organizations.

With funding from Irish Aid and other donors, **I AM A GIRL VI Project** is being implemented by Fields of Life, East Africa and other partners from July 2025 to June 2028 in Butebo, Butaleja, and Namutumba districts, with the overall goal of alleviating barriers to education for adolescent girls and boys in 34 primary schools, 6 secondary schools, and 120 surrounding communities.



Fields of Life (FOL) is a non-denominational Christian international development organisation with over 30 years' experience implementing programmes in education, Water, Sanitation and Hygiene (WASH), gender equality, and Christian outreach across East Africa.

The meeting aimed to secure national-level support for the project, align it with national policy frameworks, validate baseline findings, strengthen multi-sectoral coordination, and clarify stakeholder roles in implementation.

Meeting Objectives

The meeting sought to:

- Secure high-level endorsement and stakeholder buy-in for the project.
- Establish a shared understanding of the project scope, objectives, and sustainability mechanisms.
- Align project interventions with relevant national policy frameworks.
- Strengthen collaboration among stakeholders to avoid duplication of efforts.
- Validate and contextualize findings from the project baseline assessment.



Opening remarks

Executive Director Fields of Life, East Africa

In her opening remarks, the **Executive Director of Fields of Life East Africa, Ms. Esther N. Ssempebwa**, provided a brief overview of the organisation's journey, highlighting key institutional milestones from over 30 years of work in Uganda. She reflected on Fields of Life's sustained commitment to community development through programmes in education, Water, Sanitation and Hygiene (WASH), gender equality, and Christian outreach.



Her remarks offered important context for participants, enabling the audience to appreciate the organisation's longstanding presence, partnerships, and impact in supporting vulnerable children and communities across Uganda.

About the Project:

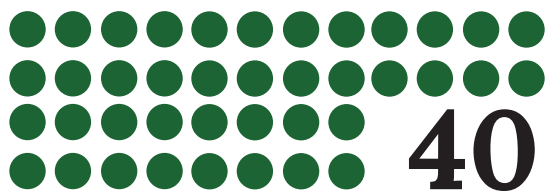


Moses Magala, WASH Coordinator at Fields of Life, East Africa, presented the project preamble, providing an overview of the initiative's background, objectives, and intended impact. He emphasized the project's holistic approach, which integrates education, Water, Sanitation and Hygiene (WASH), gender equality, and Christian outreach. He noted that this integrated model is designed to strengthen supportive learning environments and improve school retention, wellbeing, and overall development of children in the target communities.

- I AM A GIRL VI Project is funded by Irish Aid and being implemented by Fields of Life; East Africa in partnership with Hamiza Development Foundation in Butebo, Butaleja, and Namutumba districts for three years (July 2025 – June 2028).
- The project aims to alleviate barriers to education for adolescent girls and boys in 34 primary schools, 6 secondary schools, and 120 surrounding communities in Eastern Uganda.
- Key interventions focus on improving personal hygiene, promoting school enrollment and regular attendance, and supporting teenage mothers to return to and complete school.
- The project in addition promotes child protection awareness, menstrual hygiene management, prevention of gender-based violence, stakeholder accountability for children's learning, sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHR) awareness, and economic empowerment of schools and households to strengthen resilience and self-reliance.

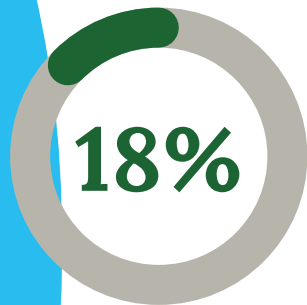
Key Statistics

from the baseline survey



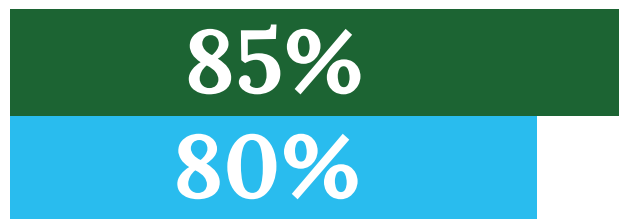
40

schools surveyed in
120 surrounding communities.



18%

of parents support school feeding through meals, food contributions, or school feeding initiatives.



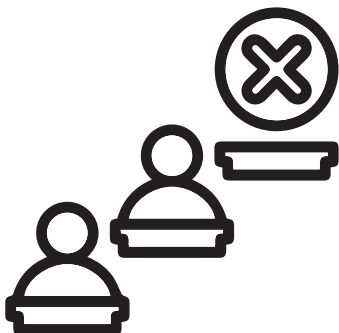
85%

Learners

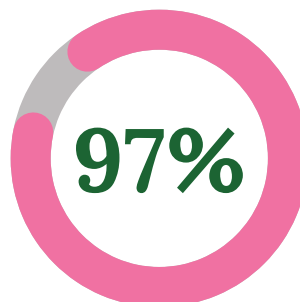
80%

School Days

Up to 85% of learners attend 80% of school days, but girls face more attendance interruptions due to domestic duties, menstruation challenges, and vulnerability to abuse.

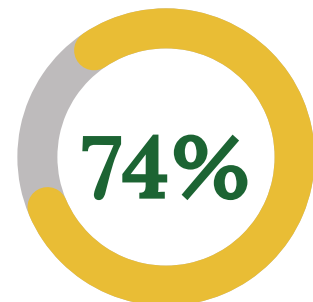


Sharp decline in enrolment from Primary One to Primary Seven, with upper classes significantly smaller.



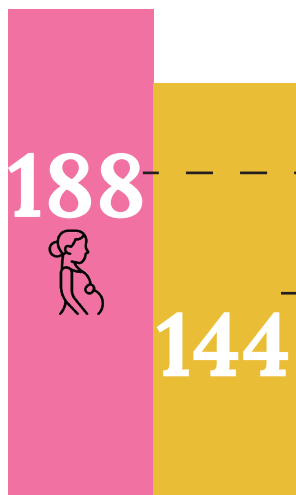
97%

completion rate among learners who reach candidate classes, regardless of performance.



74%

completion rate for learners with disabilities, indicating accessibility challenges.



188



144

teenage mothers identified across the 40 schools.

cases recorded in Butebo District alone.

Weak documentation systems make planning and support difficult.

14%

handwashing compliance at critical moments.

1 Latrine stance for approximately
122 Learners

far above recommended standards.

Key Deliberations and Stakeholder Contributions



The keynote address was delivered by **Hon. Agnes Amede, Member of Parliament for Butebo District**, who highlighted a broad range of social, economic, and structural issues as barriers to education for adolescent girls and boys. She also pointed out how collaboration between government, communities, and development partners could help address these challenges.

- Welcomed the project's holistic and research-informed approach to addressing barriers to education.
- Acknowledged the Government of Uganda for creating an enabling environment for partnerships with civil society.
- Highlighted persistent barriers to girls' education, including teenage pregnancy, child marriage, poverty, domestic violence, and school dropout, noting the cycle of poverty affecting learning opportunities.
- Emphasized the importance of strengthening political leadership and district-level support to advance education outcomes, particularly for girls.
- Called for stronger community accountability mechanisms and active mobilization of district leadership structures to support project implementation and improve school retention as well as sustainability of the initiative.
- Committed to supporting the project and addressing institutional bottlenecks that may hinder its implementation.

Ms. Atako Naome, Education Advisor from Embassy of Ireland reaffirmed the Embassy's commitment to supporting quality education for both girls and boys, noting that sustainable results depend on coordinated action among partners and strong systems that track progress and address emerging challenges.



Key points from her remarks:

- Emphasized the importance of strong governance systems, noting that when governance structures are weak, programme outcomes are often compromised.
- Highlighted the need for robust monitoring and accountability mechanisms to track programme progress and ensure intended results are achieved.
- Encouraged partners to document key project outputs, progress, and gaps to support learning and continuous improvement.
- Noted the importance of tracking critical indicators such as teenage pregnancy and other barriers that affect school retention.
- Called for partners to adapt and work differently where necessary to achieve results and respond to emerging challenges.
- Stressed the value of strengthening a multi-sectoral approach, bringing together education, community, and governance actors to address barriers to education more effectively.

Key Deliberations and Stakeholder Contributions

Ms. Irene Munyango, Assistant Commissioner for Adolescent Health at the Ministry of Health, highlighted the persistent challenge of teenage pregnancy as a longstanding barrier to education. She emphasized the importance of coordinated health and education interventions to address adolescent health issues that affect school attendance, retention, and overall wellbeing of young people.



Key Recommendations:

- Establishing structured call-in support mechanisms for children and vulnerable families.
- Addressing hygiene and sanitation barriers that affect girls' school attendance and dignity.
- Implementing evidence-based interventions informed by baseline data.
- Integrating project data into national systems such as DHIS II and LMIS.
- Conducting regular data reviews to identify trends, gaps, and service delivery needs.
- Building on existing government programs and structures to maximize impact and avoid duplication.
- She also called upon stakeholders to leverage existing government initiatives, such as the Parish Development Model, to strengthen community-level interventions that support adolescent health and education outcomes.



Rev. Nathan Mugalu a senior member of Interreligious Council of Uganda highlighted the critical role of religion and faith-based institutions in shaping community values and addressing social and educational challenges.

He emphasized that religious leaders are trusted voices who can influence attitudes and behaviours that affect children's education.

Key highlights from his remarks:

- Emphasized the influence of religion in shaping community attitudes and decisions about education.
- Noted that religious leaders are trusted community influencers who can advocate for positive social change.
- Highlighted the role of faith institutions in promoting school enrollment, retention, and completion, noting that many schools in Uganda are founded or managed by religious organizations.
- Pointed out that challenges such as teenage pregnancy, poverty, disease, and school dropout require responses that consider cultural and religious contexts.
- Encouraged engaging men and fathers through religious platforms to support girls' education.
- Proposed integrating theology with gender, education, and health programming ("theo-gender integration") to strengthen community responses.
- Emphasized the need for a holistic approach involving families, communities, schools, religious institutions, and government systems to improve education outcomes.

Panel discussion

of experts



The breakfast meeting featured a panel discussion comprising sector experts from government, civil society, and development partners. The session provided a platform to share insights, experiences, and practical approaches for alleviating barriers to education for adolescent girls and boys.

Antoinnette Angwech

Supervisor – National Child Helpline SAUTI, 116

- Strengthen national-level coordination and oversight mechanisms.
- Address intervention gaps while scaling up awareness and advocacy initiatives.
- Enhance collaboration with the National Child Helpline to strengthen child protection reporting and response systems.
- Utilize existing policy frameworks, including the National Parenting Policy.
- Strengthen implementation of the National Child Policy (2020).
- Improve follow-up mechanisms for children who drop out of school.
- Promote multi-sectoral collaboration to avoid duplication of interventions.

Dr. Joyce Mulebeke Abaliwano

Minister of Gender and culture- Busoga kingdom

Dr. Joyce Abaliwano highlighted several key areas requiring attention to address barriers to education of adolescent girls and boys:

- Increased deliberate focus on girls' empowerment and education.
- Piloting school feeding programs to improve school attendance and retention.
- Addressing stigma affecting refugee learners within host communities.
- Tackling teenage pregnancy and harmful cultural practices affecting girls.
- Strengthening Gender Norms and Social Change programming.
- Engaging boda boda riders and community groups to support mindset change initiatives.
- Packaging MGLSD behavioural change interventions into a coordinated

Panel discussion

of experts

Rosette Nanyanzi **Technical Advisor- Gender unit-MoES**

Ms. Rosette Nanyanzi highlighted the importance of aligning stakeholder efforts with government policies and guidelines aimed at promoting safe and inclusive education environments. She emphasized the need for stronger collaboration with families, communities, and government institutions to address barriers affecting learners.

- Noted that the Government has established policies and guidelines (developed in 2015 and revised in 2020) to help prevent teenage pregnancy and HIV among learners.
- Emphasized that these guidelines are key instruments supporting the school re-entry of teenage mothers.
- Encouraged organizations to work with local structures and families to strengthen meaningful parenting and child support.
- Highlighted that basic needs such as mid-day meals and sanitary pads are important parental responsibilities that support school attendance and retention.
- Stressed the need to create safe learning environments by equipping teachers with gender-responsive programmes.
- Encouraged support for young people to use social media positively and responsibly in the digital age.
- Called on Civil Society Organizations to collaborate with the Ministry of Education in implementing the Life Skills Toolkit for adolescent girls and boys.
- Called for stronger multi-sector collaboration, including with the Ministries of Finance, Agriculture, and Water and Sanitation, to address broader factors affecting education outcomes.

Ms. Betty Nehishwe **Senior Probation and Social welfare Officer- Butaleja district**

Spotted barriers to education of adolescent girls and boys including emotional barriers sighting social media that reduces attention span of affecting their academic performance.

- Motivational barriers where most learners lack role models in society to support the focus on future
- Personal barriers including physical and cognitive barriers.
- Language barriers where children in villages use speak local language yet examinations are set in English.
- Emphasizes that in a bid to achieve better education outcomes these barriers have to be addressed.

Mr. Mudhasi Ronald Davis **Head teacher- Namutumba district**

- Pointed out teenage pregnancy and poverty as key barriers to education of adolescent girls and boys.
- Asked stakeholders to prioritize counselling and guidance of learners for better education outcomes.

Key Lessons Learned

Several key insights emerged from the meeting:

- Alignment with national policy frameworks strengthens project legitimacy and district-level implementation.
- Cultural and religious leaders play a critical role as community change agents.
- Data-driven programming enhances accountability, learning, and decision-making.
- Strong multi-sectoral coordination is essential to maximize resources and avoid duplication of interventions.



Next Steps / Action Points

- Strengthen coordination between Fields of Life and relevant government ministries to ensure alignment with national policies.
- Engage religious and cultural leaders to support community sensitization and promote girls' education.
- Implement community awareness initiatives addressing teenage pregnancy, child marriage, and school dropout.
- Integrate project data into national systems such as DHIS II and LMIS and conduct regular data reviews.
- Strengthen collaboration with the National Child Helpline to improve child protection reporting and response.
- Promote multi-sectoral collaboration at district level to enhance coordination and avoid duplication.
- Support school retention initiatives such as school feeding, WASH improvements, and mentorship programs.
- Strengthen community accountability structures to support child protection and education outcomes.
- Engage men and boys in promoting positive gender norms and supporting girls' education.
- Explore integration of mental health and psychosocial support within schools.



Conclusion

- The National Project Inception Meeting provided an important platform for engaging key national stakeholders and building a shared understanding of the I AM GIRL 6 Project.
- The discussions reaffirmed the importance of a coordinated, multi-sectoral approach in addressing barriers affecting girls' education, protection, and wellbeing.
- Stakeholders expressed strong commitment to supporting the project and emphasized the need to strengthen collaboration between government institutions, cultural and religious leaders, and development partners.
- The insights shared during the meeting will guide effective implementation and ensure that the project contributes meaningfully to improving educational opportunities and life outcomes for girls in the target districts.

Photo Gallery



Our Vision

Is to see skilled young people, inspired by faith, hope, and love, leading transformation within their communities.



Alleviating Barriers To Education Of Adolescent Girls And Boys



fieldsoflife



@FieldsofLife1995



fields-of-life-trust



fields_of_life

fieldsoflife.org

NORTHERN IRELAND (HEAD OFFICE)

FIELDS OF LIFE
25 Carr Road
Craigavon, Co. Armagh
N. Ireland BT63 5WG
T: +44 (0)28 3839 0395
E: info@fieldsoflife.org

REPUBLIC OF IRELAND (DUBLIN OFFICE)

FIELDS OF LIFE
Treetops
Brides Glen Road
Shankill, Dublin 18, Ireland
T: +353 1 282 7777
E: info@fieldsoflife.org

REPUBLIC OF IRELAND (CORK OFFICE)

FIELDS OF LIFE
15 Oakfield Park
Glanmire,
County Cork, Ireland
T: +353 87 8146910
E: info@fieldsoflife.org

GREAT BRITAIN

FIELDS OF LIFE GB
1090b Galley Drive,
Kent Science Park,
Sittingbourne Kent,
England ME9 8AG
T: +44 (0)1795 474262
E: info@fieldsoflife.org

Event management and compilation of report by:

Wanda Communications Ltd

wandacommunicationsug@gmail.com

X | @Wandacommunicationsug

LinkedIn | Wanda Communications